near-vertical hill faces and the posts at around 5,000m, with a few as high as 5,485m. The operational area was divided into two sub-sectors: Kargil and Batalik. The Indian Army's 121 Infantry Brigade, part of 3 Infantry Division, covered the area between Mushkoh and Batalik with its HQ at Kargil. The division's other brigades were 70 Infantry Brigade in the Batalik sub-sector, 114 Infantry Brigade in the Kashmir Valley and Siachen, and 102 Infantry Brigade with three battalions in Siachen and the fourth in an area called Sub-Sector West.

Pakistani forces had started infiltrating across the Indian side of the LC in October 1998, but the infiltration was detected and reported only on 3 May 1999. Patrols sent by 3 PUNJAB to investigate detected a few intruders and even suffered casualties when they engaged them. Reconnaissance helicopters were also fired at by machine guns from the ridgeline, but no serious effort was made against the intruders except for moving two battalions of 70 Infantry Brigade from the Kashmir Valley to the Batalik sub-sector.

On 10 May an ammunition dump near Kargil was destroyed by Pakistani artillery fire that was regularly harassing movement on the NH-1A. A patrol of 4 JAT came under heavy fire from a winter-vacated post near Bajrang Post in the Kaksar Sector on 14 May. Unable to withdraw and out of ammunition, the patrol was surrounded and captured. The men were held captive for over three weeks, tortured and decapitated. An Indian Army platoon-strength rescue attempt had to be aborted because of coordinated fire from fortified positions in which an officer and a havildar were killed. Repeated attempts to retrieve the captives' bodies failed until the post was finally overrun by another unit in late June. On 21 May, an IAF English Electric Canberra flying a photo-reconnaissance sortie was hit by a Pakistan *Anza* surface-to-air missile (SAM). This transformed the situation, as the presence of SAMs would seriously affect IAF operations in the area.